Understanding academic or technical vocabulary

Practical guide for students | D02-ST

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Learning a subject through English involves understanding and using specialist terms. Focus on what important words mean in your subject and how they help you explain ideas.

1. Choose important terms

Start with terms highlighted in your course materials or glossary, repeated in explanations, or needed for an upcoming task. Ask your teacher which terms are essential if you are unsure.

2. Check the meaning in context

Read the sentence and surrounding explanation. Look for a definition, example or diagram.

A familiar word may have a different meaning in your subject. Check a course glossary, textbook or suitable dictionary rather than choosing the first definition you find.

3. Keep a useful vocabulary record

For each important term, record:

- The term and its meaning in this subject.
- An example, diagram or common phrase showing how it is used.
- A translation or explanation in another language, if helpful.

Check that any translation matches the subject meaning.

4. Practise recalling the meaning

Cover the explanation and try to explain the term yourself. Then check and correct your answer.

You can also work in the other direction: read an explanation and recall the term. Revisit terms over several study sessions.

5. Use terms to explain subject ideas

Use the vocabulary in an answer, discussion, calculation or explanation. Go beyond repeating a definition: show how the term applies to a particular situation.

6. Ask a focused question

Show your teacher the term in its sentence and explain what you think it means.

For example: “Does ‘significant’ here mean important, or does it have a specific statistical meaning?”

Example

Term: Revenue

- **Meaning in business:** Income a business earns from its normal activities, such as selling goods or services, before expenses are deducted.
- **Example:** A café sells 100 drinks for 40,000 VND each. Its revenue from those sales is 4,000,000 VND.
- **Important distinction:** Revenue is different from profit. To calculate profit, the café also needs to account for its expenses.
- **Check your understanding:** Can you explain how a café’s revenue could increase while its profit decreases?

7. Check your vocabulary record

- I have selected terms that matter for my subject.
- My explanations match the meaning in the course materials.
- I have included examples or useful phrases.
- I practise recalling meanings rather than only rereading them.
- I can use the terms to explain subject ideas.

If you still need help: bring the term, the sentence where you found it and your attempted explanation to your teacher or relevant study-support service.

Supporting Sources

RMIT University. (n.d.). *Academic vocabulary*. Learning Lab. https://learninglab.rmit.edu.au/sites/default/files/vocabulary.pdf

Supports checking meanings against the subject context, using subject dictionaries and glossaries, and recording definitions and examples. See pp. 1–2.

Nation, P. (2022). *The principles of vocabulary learning (and any other kind of learning)*. TESOLANZ. https://www.tesolanz.org.nz/resources/paul-nation-the-principles-of-vocabulary-learning/

Supports selecting useful learning content, practising recall of words and meanings, spacing practice, and using vocabulary in context.

Vanderbilt University, English Language Center. (2020). *Academic vocabulary guide: Word cards*. https://www.vanderbilt.edu/elc/wp-content/uploads/sites/50/2024/11/VUELC-Academic-Vocabulary-Guide-Word-Cards.pdf